

Pauline created the leading role in Strauss's first opera, *Guntram* (a failure on its premiere in 1894), and inspired his abiding love affair with the soprano voice. He once said of her: "She sang my songs with an expression and a poetry such as I have never heard since." She remained his ideal interpreter even when her voice grew more fragile and her platform manner (including shameless applause-seeking antics during her husband's piano postludes) increasingly outrageous.

Operatic success

Between 1894 and 1906, Strauss composed some 70 songs, many of which he performed with Pauline. But in the new century, his creative life was dominated by opera. After the satirical *Feuersnot* (1901), the composer embraced Modernism with the violently compressed *Salome* (1905), to a play by Oscar Wilde, and *Elektra* (1909). Both operas probed emotional and sexual extremes by taking dissonance to a new level; and both caused a sensation. Strauss built a luxurious villa at the resort of Garmisch in Bavaria on the proceeds of *Salome*. A study in morbid hysteria, *Elektra* contains the most discordantly "advanced" music that Strauss ever composed. The opera was his first collaboration with the Viennese author Hugo von Hofmannsthal, who then also provided the libretto for a very different work, the ever popular *Der Rosenkavalier* (1911). Retreating from Modernist anarchy, Strauss wrote a bittersweet comedy of manners that mingles Wagnerian techniques (including subtle thematic transformation) with a Mozartian lightness and grace. If *Figaro* has a successor, this is it.